

PSY405 - Lesson 33

Albert Bandura's Social Learning Theory

Albert Bandura wanted to answer a simple but powerful question:

| “How do humans learn behavior in real life?”

He noticed something important:

- We **don't learn only by rewards and punishments**
- We **learn a lot just by watching others**

So his theory connects **three things together**:

1. **The person (thinking, beliefs, expectations)**
2. **The behavior (what we do)**
3. **The environment (people, situations, media)**

This interaction is the heart of **Social Learning Theory**.

What is Social Learning Theory?

Social Learning Theory explains behavior as the result of an interaction between:

- **Cognitive factors** (thinking, beliefs, expectations)
- **Behavioral factors** (actions)
- **Environmental factors** (models, rewards, punishments)

Plain English Meaning

We learn:

- By **thinking**
- By **doing**
- By **watching others**

—all at the same time.



Who Was Albert Bandura? (Biographical Sketch)

- Born: **1925**, Canada
- Field: **Psychology (Learning & Personality)**
- Famous for:
 - **Modeling**
 - **Observational learning**
 - **Bobo Doll experiments**
 - **Reciprocal determinism**
 - **Self-efficacy**

Bandura challenged earlier psychologists like **Skinner**, who believed learning happens *only* through reward and punishment.



Reconceptualization of Reinforcement

Traditional View (Behaviorists like Skinner)

| Learning happens only when you are rewarded or punished.

Bandura's New Idea

| Learning can happen without direct reinforcement.

Key Term: Vicarious Reinforcement

Definition: Learning by observing someone else being rewarded or punished.



Example

- You see your classmate praised for answering confidently.
- You think: *"If I speak confidently, I might also get praise."*
- You speak up — even though **you were never rewarded before**.

➡ You learned **indirectly**.

👁️ Observational Learning (Modeling)

Core Idea

| Most human behavior is learned by observation.

Key Term: Model

A **model** is any person whose behavior is observed and copied.

📌 Models can be:

- Parents
 - Teachers
 - Friends
 - Celebrities
 - Politicians
 - Movie heroes
 - Cartoon characters (yes, even Superman)
-

🧩 Principles of Observational Learning

Bandura says **4 processes** must occur for observational learning.

1 Attentional Processes

Definition

The degree to which we **pay attention** to the model.

Plain English

We can't learn if we're **not paying attention**.

📌 What increases attention?

- Attractive models
- Powerful models
- Similar models
- Famous models

Example

- Children pay more attention to **movie heroes** than teachers.
 - Students imitate **popular classmates**, not quiet ones.
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Retention Processes

Definition

The ability to **remember** what was observed.

Plain English

We store observed behavior in our **memory**.

How?

- **Mental images** (pictures in mind)
- **Verbal symbols** (words, instructions)

Example

You remember:

- How your teacher solved a math problem
 - How a hero fought in a movie
-

Production Processes

Definition

The ability to **reproduce** the behavior.

Plain English

Knowing is not enough — you must be able to **do it**.

 Example

- You know how to drive by watching
 - But you need practice to actually drive
-

4 Motivational Processes

Definition

The reason **why** a person performs the behavior.

Plain English

We copy behavior only if we **expect benefits**.

 Example

- If aggression is rewarded → more aggression
 - If aggression is punished → less aggression
-



The Bobo Doll Experiment (Very Important)

What Happened?

Children watched:

- **Aggressive adult** hitting a doll
- **Non-aggressive adult** ignoring the doll

Results:

- Children copied **exact aggressive actions**
- No reward was given
- No punishment was given

What It Proved:

1. Children learn **new behaviors by observation**

2. Learning can happen **without reinforcement**
 3. Cognition (thinking, memory) plays a key role
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Media and Aggression

Bandura found that:

- **Live models**
- **Movies**
- **Cartoons**

👉 All have **equal power** in teaching aggression.

📌 Examples from your lesson:

- Action films (Van Dam, Sultan Rahi)
- TV dramas (e.g., *Waris*)
- Cartoons with fighting heroes

💡 **Important Point**

| Media doesn't just entertain — it teaches behavior.

Vicarious Emotional Learning

Definition

Learning **emotional reactions** by observing others.

📌 Example (Buzzer Experiment)

- Person watches a model react in pain
- Observer later feels fear **without ever being shocked**

➡ Fear was **learned indirectly**

Reciprocal Determinism (VERY IMPORTANT)

Definition

Behavior is shaped by **three interlocking factors**:

1. Person (thoughts, beliefs)
2. Environment (social situation)
3. Behavior (actions)

Each influences the others.

Simple Example

A student talks in class:

- Personality: Talkative
- Environment: Friends encourage talking
- Behavior: Talking increases future talking

➡ All three influence each other continuously.

📌 People are:

- **Not robots**
 - **Not completely free**
 - But active participants in shaping their lives
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The Self-System

Definition

A **self-system** is a set of cognitive processes used to:

- Observe
 - Judge
 - Regulate behavior
-

Self-Observation

We watch our own behavior.

 Example

- "How well did I speak?"
 - "Was I confident?"
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ii Judgmental Process

We compare behavior with standards.

 Standards come from:

- Past performance
- Social comparison
- Cultural norms

 Example

Comparing yourself to:

- A topper → feel inadequate
 - A weaker student → feel confident
-

iii Self-Reaction

We reward or punish ourselves mentally.

 Example

- Pride → self-reward
 - Guilt → self-punishment
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Moral Disengagement (Very Important)

Sometimes people **switch off** their self-control.

They justify wrong behavior by:

- Moral justification ("It's for a good cause")
- Euphemistic labeling ("Collateral damage")

- Displacement of responsibility ("Orders from above")
- Dehumanizing victims

👉 Similar to **Freud's defense mechanisms**

Applications to Therapy

Bandura applied his theory to **treat fears and phobias**.

Modeling Therapy

Patients:

1. Watch a calm model
2. Practice behavior gradually
3. Gain confidence

📌 Best method: **Participant Modeling**

- Watch
- Practice
- Repeat

📌 Example

Snake phobia treatment:

- Watching others touch snake
 - Gradually doing it themselves
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Research Focus

Bandura's research mainly focused on:

- Aggression
 - Media violence
 - Children's learning
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Summary

- Learning = **Observe + Think + Act**
 - Behavior learned **without reinforcement**
 - Media strongly influences behavior
 - Person, behavior & environment interact
 - Self-regulation guides actions
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Evaluation

Strengths

- ✓ Explains real-life learning
- ✓ Includes cognition
- ✓ Strong research support

Limitation

- ✗ Less focus on unconscious motives

Short Question Answers

Q1: What is Bandura's Social Learning Theory?

Answer:

Bandura's Social Learning Theory explains human behavior as a result of the interaction between **cognitive processes** (thinking, beliefs, expectations), **behavioral patterns** (actions), and **environmental factors** (social situations, models). It emphasizes that people can learn **new behaviors by observing others** (modeling) without direct reinforcement.

Explanation:

Bandura challenged traditional behaviorism (like Skinner), which said we only learn through rewards and punishments. He found that humans are more complex: we **observe**, **think**, and then **act**. Behavior is influenced not just by the environment or rewards but also by **how we interpret what we see**.

Example:

A child sees their older sibling helping a neighbor. Later, the child imitates this helpful behavior **without being told or rewarded**, just by observing.

Tips:

- Remember **OBSERVE → THINK → ACT**.
 - Focus on the **interaction of 3 factors**: Person, Behavior, Environment.
 - Think of **"learning by watching"** as the core idea.
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Q2: What is observational learning or modeling?

Answer:

Observational learning, also called **modeling**, is the process of learning new behaviors by **watching others perform them**. A **model** can be a real person, a fictional character, or someone in media. Observers can later imitate the behavior if it is noticed, remembered, and motivated.

Explanation:

Humans do not need to perform a behavior themselves to learn it. Instead, by **observing models**, we encode the behavior into memory and later reproduce it. Bandura's experiments, like the **Bobo doll study**, proved this.

Example:

Children watched adults act aggressively toward a Bobo doll. Later, the children themselves acted aggressively, showing that they had **learned by observation**.

Tips:

- Use the mnemonic: **"See → Learn → Do"**.

- Remember, models **don't need to reward us** for learning to occur.
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Q3: What are the four processes of observational learning?

Answer:

Bandura identified **four key processes** necessary for observational learning:

1. **Attentional Process:** Paying attention to the model.
2. **Retention Process:** Remembering the behavior.
3. **Production Process:** Being able to reproduce the behavior.
4. **Motivational Process:** Having the desire or reason to perform the behavior.

Explanation:

For learning to happen, it's not enough to just watch. We need to:

- Notice the behavior (**attention**)
- Store it in memory (**retention**)
- Have the physical/cognitive skills to do it (**production**)
- Want to do it, often influenced by anticipated rewards (**motivation**)

Example:

- Watching a chef make a recipe (**attention**)
- Remembering the steps (**retention**)
- Actually cooking it (**production**)
- Wanting to do it to impress friends (**motivation**)

Tips:

- Mnemonic: **A.R.P.M.** → **Attention, Retention, Production, Motivation**
 - Always link to **real-life learning by observation**.
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Q4: What is vicarious reinforcement?

Answer:

Vicarious reinforcement is the process of **learning by observing the consequences of someone else's behavior**. If the observed behavior is rewarded, the observer is more likely to imitate it; if punished, the observer is less likely to copy it.

Explanation:

This shows that learning can happen **without directly experiencing rewards or punishments**. Observing others gives us **cognitive insight** about what is beneficial or harmful.

Example:

- A student sees a peer praised for answering a question correctly → more likely to answer next time.
- Another student sees a peer scolded for talking in class → less likely to talk.

Tips:

- Think of it as "**learning from other people's experiences**".
 - Connect with media examples: TV shows, movies, or cartoons teaching moral or immoral behavior.
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Q5: What was the Bobo doll experiment and its findings?

Answer:

The **Bobo doll experiment** (Bandura, Ross & Ross, 1961) involved children watching adults act aggressively toward a Bobo doll. Later, when placed with the doll, children **imitated the aggressive behaviors** they had observed. Children who saw non-aggressive adults showed less aggression than the control group.

Explanation:

The study demonstrated **observational learning**, showing that:

- Novel behaviors can be learned without reinforcement
- Children can imitate both **physical and verbal aggression**
- Exposure to models, even fictional or symbolic, affects behavior

Example:

- A child watches an adult hit a doll → the child hits it later
- Another child watches an adult ignore the doll → the child plays gently

Tips:

- Remember: **Aggressive model → Aggressive child**
 - Key takeaway: Learning happens **without practicing first**.
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Q6: What is reciprocal determinism?

Answer:

Reciprocal determinism is the idea that **behavior, personal factors (cognition), and the environment all influence each other continuously**. None of these factors operate alone; they are interdependent.

Explanation:

Unlike earlier theories that said behavior is shaped only by environment or personality, Bandura argued that:

- Our actions affect our environment
- Our environment affects our actions
- Our thinking shapes and is shaped by both

Example:

- A student talks in class (behavior)
- Friends laugh and encourage talking (environment)

- The student feels confident (personal factor)
- Result → talking continues; environment and confidence reinforce each other

Tips:

- Think of it as a **feedback loop**: Person ↔ Behavior ↔ Environment
 - Helps understand why people are active agents, not passive.
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Q7: What is the self-system in Social Learning Theory?

Answer:

The self-system is a set of **cognitive structures** that allow individuals to **observe, judge, and regulate their own behavior**. It includes three components:

1. **Self-observation**: Monitoring our behavior
2. **Judgmental process**: Comparing behavior against standards
3. **Self-reaction**: Rewarding or punishing ourselves mentally based on performance

Explanation:

This shows how humans **self-regulate** without external rewards. Our behavior is guided by internal standards developed through experience, observation, and social influence.

Example:

- Studying for a test: You notice (self-observation) you haven't studied enough, compare to peers (judgment), and decide to study more (self-reaction).

Tips:

- Think: **"I watch myself, judge myself, reward/punish myself."**
 - Key term: Self-regulation → controlling your own behavior.
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Q8: What is moral disengagement?

Answer:

Moral disengagement is the process of **avoiding self-condemnation when engaging in unethical behavior**. People justify or distort their actions so they do not feel guilty.

Explanation:

Bandura identified several ways:

- Moral justification: "I'm doing it for a good cause"
- Euphemistic labeling: "Collateral damage"
- Displacement of responsibility: "I was ordered"
- Dehumanization: "They deserve it"

Example:

- A student cheats on a test and thinks: "Everyone cheats, so it's okay" → avoids guilt.

Tips:

- Relate to real life or history: propaganda, excuses for bad behavior
- Think: "**How people trick themselves into feeling okay about wrong acts**"

Q9: How is Social Learning Theory applied in therapy?

Answer:

Social Learning Theory is used in **behavior therapy** to reduce fears, phobias, or undesirable behaviors by:

1. **Modeling:** Patients observe a calm model interacting with a feared object
2. **Guided practice:** Patients gradually practice the behavior themselves
3. **Reinforcement:** Positive experiences encourage continued behavior

Explanation:

This is known as **participant modeling**. Therapy shows that **emotional responses can be unlearned or reduced** using observational learning principles.

Example:

- Snake phobia: Patient watches therapist handle a snake → tries it themselves → fear decreases
- Phobia therapy combines **observation + practice + relaxation**.

Tips:

- Think: "**Watch → Try → Reduce fear**"
- Connect with real-life fears: public speaking, animals, exams.

MCQs

True/False MCQs

1. **Bandura believed that learning can occur without reinforcement.**

- True 

Explanation: Bandura showed that humans can learn by **observing others**, even if no reward or punishment occurs (vicarious learning).

2. **Observational learning is only effective if the observer is directly rewarded for the behavior.**

- False 

Explanation: Observers can learn behavior **without direct reinforcement**, by watching a model being rewarded or punished.

3. **Reciprocal determinism means that behavior influences the environment but not the person.**

- False 

Explanation: Reciprocal determinism states that **person, behavior, and environment all influence each other continuously**.

4. **The Bobo doll experiment demonstrated that children can imitate aggressive behavior after observing a model.**

- True 

Explanation: Children in the study copied both physical and verbal aggression after watching adults act aggressively.

5. **Moral disengagement allows individuals to avoid self-condemnation for unethical behavior.**

- True 

Explanation: People use justifications or excuses to feel morally okay despite wrongdoing.

Conceptual MCQs

1. **Which of the following is NOT a process of observational learning?**

- A) Attentional
- B) Retention
- C) Production
- D) Punishment

- **Answer:** D) Punishment 

Explanation: Observational learning involves **Attention, Retention, Production, Motivation**. Punishment is not a process but may affect motivation.

1. **Vicarious reinforcement refers to:**

- A) Rewarding oneself for personal achievement
- B) Learning by observing consequences of another's behavior
- C) Immediate feedback after performing a task
- D) Practicing a skill repeatedly

- **Answer:** B) Learning by observing consequences of another's behavior 

Explanation: Vicarious reinforcement occurs when **an observer sees someone else rewarded or punished**, influencing future behavior.

1. **The self-system includes all of the following EXCEPT:**

- A) Self-observation
- B) Judgmental process
- C) Self-reaction
- D) Classical conditioning

- **Answer:** D) Classical conditioning 

Explanation: The self-system is about **self-regulation**: observing, judging, and reacting to one's own behavior. Classical conditioning is not part of it.

1. **Reciprocal determinism emphasizes:**

- A) Behavior is fully controlled by the environment
- B) Behavior is independent of personal cognition
- C) Behavior, environment, and personal factors influence each other
- D) Behavior is genetically determined

- **Answer:** C) Behavior, environment, and personal factors influence each other 

Explanation: Bandura's theory views behavior as a **continuous feedback loop** with cognition and environment.

Situational MCQs

1. **A student watches a classmate receive praise for answering a question correctly. The next day, the observing student answers confidently. This is an example of:**

- A) Classical conditioning
- B) Operant conditioning
- C) Vicarious reinforcement
- D) Moral disengagement

- **Answer:** C) Vicarious reinforcement ✓

Explanation: The student learned by **observing another's reward** and was motivated to imitate.

1. **A child sees a violent cartoon hero and later mimics aggressive actions on a toy. According to Bandura, which processes explain this behavior?**

A) Attention, Retention, Production, Motivation ✓

B) Classical conditioning only

C) Positive reinforcement

D) Moral disengagement

- **Answer:** A) Attention, Retention, Production, Motivation ✓

Explanation: Observational learning requires **seeing the behavior, remembering it, being able to perform it, and having motivation.**

1. **A teenager cheats on an exam and justifies it by thinking "Everyone cheats in this class." This is an example of:**

A) Self-reaction

B) Reciprocal determinism

C) Moral disengagement ✓

D) Vicarious reinforcement

- **Answer:** C) Moral disengagement ✓

Explanation: The teen **avoids self-condemnation** by rationalizing unethical behavior.

1. **A student studies hard and consistently performs well. Later, they self-reward by taking themselves out for a treat. Which component of Bandura's self-system is illustrated?**

A) Self-observation

B) Judgmental process

C) Self-reaction ✓

D) Reciprocal determinism

- **Answer:** C) Self-reaction ✓

Explanation: Self-reaction is about **mentally rewarding or punishing oneself** based on behavior.

1. **In therapy for a phobia, a patient watches a model interact safely with a feared object, then gradually tries it themselves. This is called:**

A) Classical conditioning

B) Participant modeling ✓

C) Operant conditioning

D) Moral disengagement

- **Answer:** B) Participant modeling ✓

Explanation: Therapy uses **observational learning + guided practice** to reduce fear.

Tricky MCQs

1. **Which statement best reflects Bandura's critique of Skinner's behaviorism?**

A) Learning is purely genetic

B) Behavior is only shaped by the environment ✓

C) Reinforcement is unnecessary for all learning

D) People never imitate others

- **Answer:** C) Reinforcement is unnecessary for all learning ✓

Explanation: Bandura argued that humans can learn **without reinforcement** by observing others (vicarious learning).

1. **Which scenario shows reciprocal determinism?**

A) A shy student never talks because of an intimidating teacher

B) A student's confidence encourages peers to participate, which increases classroom interaction ✓

C) A child repeats a behavior because of direct reward

D) A person imitates a violent movie character without consequence

- **Answer:** B) A student's confidence encourages peers to participate, which increases classroom interaction ✓

Explanation: Behavior (confidence), person (self-belief), and environment (peers) **mutually influence each other**.

1. **A child watches a model get punished for aggression and decides not to imitate. This demonstrates:**

- A) Direct reinforcement
- B) Vicarious punishment ✓
- C) Self-efficacy
- D) Reciprocal determinism

- **Answer:** B) Vicarious punishment ✓

Explanation: Observing **someone else punished** discourages the observer from performing the behavior.

Cheat Sheet

1. Core Idea

Bandura: Most human behavior is learned through **observation**, not just direct reinforcement.

Behavior = Interaction of:

- **Person (cognition)** → thoughts, beliefs, expectations
- **Behavior (actions)** → what we do
- **Environment** → social context, models, media

Mnemonic: OBSERVE → THINK → ACT

2. Key Terms

Term	Definition (Plain English)	Example
Observational Learning / Modeling	Learning new behaviors by watching others	Child sees sibling helping → later helps neighbor
Model	The person/character being observed	Teacher, celebrity, superhero
Vicarious Reinforcement	Learning from rewards/punishments of others	See classmate praised → more likely to imitate
Vicarious Punishment	Learning from punishment of others	See someone scolded → avoid that behavior
Reciprocal Determinism	Person, Behavior, Environment influence each other continuously	Confident student encourages peers → classroom becomes interactive
Self-System	Cognitive structures for observing, judging, regulating behavior	Self-monitoring, self-reward, self-punishment
Self-Observation	Monitoring one's own behavior	Checking if you studied enough
Judgmental Process	Comparing behavior to standards	Comparing grades to class average
Self-Reaction	Rewarding or punishing self	Treat yourself for studying
Moral Disengagement	Justifying unethical behavior to avoid guilt	"Everyone cheats, so it's okay"
Participant Modeling	Therapy: observing + practicing behavior to overcome fear	Phobia treatment: watching therapist handle snake

3. Processes of Observational Learning

Mnemonic: A.R.P.M. → Attention, Retention, Production, Motivation

Process	Meaning	Example
Attention	Focus on the model	Watching a chef carefully
Retention	Remember what was observed	Memorizing recipe steps
Production	Ability to reproduce behavior	Cooking the dish yourself
Motivation	Desire to perform behavior	Wanting to impress friends with cooking

4. Key Experiments

Experiment	Key Findings
Bobo Doll (1961)	Children imitate aggressive behavior after observing model
Live vs. Film vs. Cartoon Models	Children imitate aggression equally from real or symbolic models
Vicarious Emotional Learning (Buzzer Experiment)	Observers learn fear/emotion by watching model, even without direct experience

5. Reciprocal Determinism

Definition: Behavior, personal factors, and environment **all influence each other**.

Example Table:

Factor	Example	Effect
Person	Talkative student	Confidence encourages action
Behavior	Talking in class	Affects environment
Environment	Friends encourage talking	Feedback loop → more talking

Tip: Think **"Person ↔ Behavior ↔ Environment"** as a **feedback loop**.

6. Self-System Components

Component	Function	Example
Self-Observation	Monitor own behavior	Check how much you studied
Judgmental Process	Compare behavior to standards	Grade comparison with peers
Self-Reaction	Reward/punish self	Treat yourself for achieving goal

Tip: Think **"Observe → Judge → React"**.

7. Moral Disengagement Mechanisms

Mechanism	Meaning	Example
Moral Justification	"It's for a good cause"	Stealing to feed family
Euphemistic Labeling	Softening harsh acts	"Collateral damage"
Displacement of Responsibility	"Someone else made me do it"	Following orders
Dehumanization	Blaming the victim	"They deserved it"

Tip: Connect with real-life or history to memorize.

8. Applications to Therapy

- **Participant Modeling:** Observe + practice to reduce fear
- **Steps:**
 1. Observe model interacting safely
 2. Guided practice in non-threatening situation
 3. Gradual independence
- **Example:** Treating snake phobia or fear of public speaking

9. Key Points / Memory Hooks

Concept	Hook / Mnemonic	Quick Reminder
Observational Learning	See → Learn → Do	Learning without direct reinforcement
4 Processes	A.R.P.M.	Attention, Retention, Production, Motivation
Vicarious Reinforcement	"Learn from others' rewards"	Observation influences action
Reciprocal Determinism	"P.B.E. feedback loop"	Person ↔ Behavior ↔ Environment
Self-System	O.J.R.	Observe → Judge → Reward/Punish
Bobo Doll Experiment	Aggression = imitation	Children imitate models
Moral Disengagement	Justification tricks	Avoid guilt for unethical acts